



Highlights galore: A total of 200, fifties aplenty for Smriti Mandhana (in pic), a fluent Shafali Verma alongside her, and runs from the middle order — all bodes well for India as it gears up to take on similarly on-song sides with the bat in the World Cup. **Below:** Captain Harmanpreet Kaur in the final. Pics: PTI

flawless. It began the calendar year with Richa Ghosh — a potent finisher — earmarked for the no. 3 role in the batting order. A technically gifted and explosive batter, Richa adapted. The Women's Premier League's second edition brought D. Hemalatha into the equation, and she took to the job well in Bangladesh but has since struggled. Jemimah Rodrigues, who has enjoyed an on-and-off relationship with the position, now finds herself firmly in no. 5. Yastika Bhatia is on the mend after an injury. **So who is India's no. 3 for the World Cup? That there is no concrete answer yet is a bit worrying for India.**

All isn't well in the spin department either. Radha Yadav, who marked her comeback into the Indian side with solid performances, struggled to dominate in Sri Lanka. She even conceded the most runs (47) by a bowler in a women's T20 Asia Cup game in the final. Tanuja Kanwer, who was brought in for the injured Shreyanka Patil, showed promise

but was taken to the cleaners by Chamari's Lanka. Surprisingly, Asha Sobhana Joy — the leg spinner who enjoyed good returns in Bangladesh — wasn't even given a look-in during this tournament.

It's not all gloom and doom. India's batting throughout the tournament will inspire a lot of confidence. A total of 200, fifties aplenty for Smriti Mandhana, a fluent Shafali Verma alongside her, and runs from the middle order — all bodes well for India as it gears up to take on similarly on-song sides with the bat in the World Cup. If there's any department on life support in the Indian camp, it would be its fielding, and that needs resuscitation on priority.

Sri Lanka's resurgence aside, the report card was not encouraging for Asian cricket as a whole. **The tournament, although expanded, continued to be lopsided in quality for no fault of the participating nations.** With the ICC toying with expanding the World Cups too, increased exposure for nations like Nepal, Thailand, UAE and Malaysia against stronger, more established sides is the need of the hour to strengthen the health of the game in the continent.